

Decomposition

Taking a big, ambiguous goal and breaking it into ordered, doable steps — without being handed a checklist first.

The student can...	Not Yet	Approaching	Proficient	Advanced
...break a project into ordered steps without being handed a checklist.	Waits for the teacher to provide a step-by-step list; cannot name a next action independently.	Names a few steps when prompted, but order is incomplete or missing key pieces.	Independently maps out an ordered sequence before asking for help, and adjusts the plan when something changes.	Produces a sequenced breakdown unprompted, flags dependencies or risks, and helps a peer do the same.
...identify which step must come first (the blocker).	Lists tasks randomly with no sense of what must happen before something else can start.	Puts most steps in a workable order but skips at least one dependency (e.g., writing before researching).	Sequences steps so each one sets up the next and can explain why a particular step is the blocker.	Identifies the critical path and redesigns the sequence when a blocker changes.
...size each step so work can be paced.	Treats all tasks as the same effort; no sense of relative size.	Can identify big vs. small tasks but does not connect estimates to available time.	Sizes each step well enough to decide where to start and how to pace across available days.	Estimates effort, builds in buffer for likely problems, and revises estimates mid-project based on evidence.

Proficient = the competency is demonstrated reliably and independently (the target). Advanced = the student extends it unprompted.

Work & Time Organization

Managing tasks and deadlines across multiple concurrent projects; using a calendar to define and protect work time; keeping files organized so anything can be found again.

The student can...	Not Yet	Approaching	Proficient	Advanced
...use a calendar to protect work time before deadlines arrive.	Does not use a calendar; all planning is in their head or not at all.	Has deadlines written down but does not block time in advance to do the work.	Adds working sessions to a calendar before deadlines arrive and notices when two projects collide.	Proactively protects time weeks out, flags conflicts to collaborators early, and adjusts when new demands appear.
...organize files so work can be found again without a search.	Files are untitled, saved to a default location, or simply lost; cannot locate own work.	Files are saved but named inconsistently; finding them takes trial and error.	Files are named clearly and stored in a folder structure they can describe to someone else; nothing important is lost.	Maintains a system others could navigate, versions work intentionally, and can explain the logic of their structure.
...track open tasks across more than one project at a time.	Loses track of what is due when managing more than one assignment.	Tracks due dates individually but misses that two land on the same day or require shared prep time.	Maintains a running task list across all projects and updates it regularly without reminders.	Uses their system to proactively surface conflicts, reprioritize, and keep collaborators informed.

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Working with Ambiguity

Asking clarifying questions early in a project and adapting when requirements shift as more becomes known.

The student can...	Not Yet	Approaching	Proficient	Advanced
...ask clarifying questions early, not the night before something is due.	Goes silent when a project is introduced; sends questions only when the deadline is hours away.	Asks some questions but waits until stuck rather than front-loading key clarifications at the start.	Within the first day or two, asks targeted questions that remove the biggest unknowns before starting.	Anticipates ambiguities before the teacher surfaces them and drafts a working definition to validate early.
...make a stated assumption and keep working when information is incomplete.	Freezes or refuses to proceed without explicit instructions for every step.	Will move forward when told it is okay, but does not name or flag the assumption made.	States the assumption out loud ("I'm treating X as Y — let me know if that's wrong") and keeps working.	Names assumptions, weighs the risk of each, and designs the work so it can adapt quickly if an assumption is wrong.
...adapt when requirements shift mid-project.	Treats a change in scope as a crisis; restarts from scratch or shuts down.	Adjusts the work but needs reassurance before continuing and may discard still-usable material.	Acknowledges the change, identifies which parts of existing work still apply, and updates the plan without drama.	Frames the change as useful data, identifies the delta, adjusts with minimal lost work, and brings the team along.

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Initiative / Self-Starting

Getting going without being prompted; investigating a problem independently and proposing a next step before stopping or waiting on someone else. This is often the hardest shift.

The student can...	Not Yet	Approaching	Proficient	Advanced
...start work without being prompted.	Sits idle after an assignment is given; waits to be told the specific next step before doing anything.	Gets started after a general nudge ("you should probably begin") but needs that nudge every session.	Opens the project and begins on their own, without a reminder, at the expected time or earlier.	Begins before the formal start, scopes what they don't know yet, and shares early drafts to surface issues fast.
...investigate a problem before asking for help.	Asks the first question that arises without attempting to find the answer independently.	Makes one attempt to find an answer, then asks immediately if it does not work.	Makes a genuine effort to investigate (tries a different approach, searches, re-reads) and then asks a specific, informed question.	Documents what was tried before asking, frames the question precisely, and proposes a hypothesis to test.
...propose a next step when stuck.	Reports being stuck and waits for the teacher to provide the next move.	Describes the problem but offers no idea for how to proceed.	Describes the problem and names at least one concrete thing to try next.	Generates multiple options, evaluates the trade-offs briefly, and acts on the most promising one.

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Communication & Presentation

Speaking about your own work in front of a group — explaining what you did, why, and what you learned.

The student can...	Not Yet	Approaching	Proficient	Advanced
...present work to a group clearly and within time.	Reads directly from a screen or sheet with no eye contact; audience cannot follow the explanation.	Makes occasional eye contact and has a loose structure but loses the thread partway through.	Looks at the audience, follows a clear arc (what I did, why, what I learned), and finishes within time.	Tailors the arc to this specific audience, anticipates a likely question, and lands the close memorably.
...use note cards as a guide, not a script.	Either reads every word verbatim or improvises with no structure at all.	Uses notes but drifts into reading them word-for-word when nervous.	Glances at note cards to stay on track but speaks in their own words; cards hold cues, not sentences.	Uses a minimal cue system that keeps eye contact nearly continuous and recovers smoothly from any stumble.
...explain the reasoning behind their decisions, not just the output.	Describes what the project is without explaining why any choices were made.	Names a choice or two when prompted but cannot explain the reasoning unprompted.	Volunteers the reasoning behind at least one key decision and can answer "why did you do it that way?" without hesitation.	Weaves decision rationale throughout the presentation, names trade-offs considered, and invites pushback.

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Digital & Systems Fluency

Comfort with how software actually works and where information lives — understanding abstraction at a basic level. This skill is increasingly urgent as AI tools become part of everyday work.

The student can...	Not Yet	Approaching	Proficient	Advanced
...locate where a file lives and retrieve it immediately.	Cannot locate files on their own device; does not distinguish local storage, cloud, and downloads folder.	Can find a file eventually but describes its location in vague terms ("it's saved somewhere").	Can state where a file is saved and why (local vs. cloud, which folder, which account) and retrieve it immediately.	Maintains a consistent storage system, can explain it to a peer, and recovers quickly when a sync or access issue occurs.
...describe a basic mental model of how a piece of software does its job.	Treats software as a black box; has no model for what happens between input and output.	Can describe the general purpose of a tool but not how data moves through it.	Gives a simple, accurate model: input goes in, it is processed this way, output comes out — without jargon.	Applies the mental model to predict what will happen in an unfamiliar tool or when something goes wrong.
...troubleshoot when technology does not behave as expected.	Stops working and waits for someone else to fix the problem.	Tries one thing (usually restarting) and escalates immediately if it does not work.	Works through a small set of logical steps, narrows down the likely cause, and escalates with a specific description of what was tried.	Diagnoses systematically, searches for solutions independently, and documents the fix so it can be reused.

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